

The Roman army was not a static organization but evolved over the centuries to meet diverse challenges and overcome new enemies. In its early days it resembled the ancient Greek hoplite army, which was primarily made up of men who volunteered to fight to protect their city. In Rome, changes began as soon as the empire expanded. By the time of Julius Caesar (see pp.108–09) in the 1st century, the army had become a well organized, mobile fighting force. The “classic” Roman army that we know most about today is that which Caesar (pp.108–109) began and Augustus (see p.112) honed. By the reign of Trajan (98–117 CE), this is the army that seemed unbeatable to its enemies.

A developing force

In the days of the early Republic (see pp.106–07) the army was staffed by volunteers from the aristocratic families. They provided their own weapons and uniform and trained for five or six years. Small units of men

(centuries) worked as a team. They worked and lived together and fought with iron discipline, just as the Greek hoplites had done before them. As Roman power expanded, however, a professional army became vital. The general Marius (157–85 BCE) made many reforms, including opening the army to all. The practice of giving a piece of land to retired soldiers is also attributed to Marius. Caesar (100–44 BCE) oversaw a professional and well-led military force that Augustus (63 BCE–14 CE) maintained, with a stable number of legions to make up the army that would safeguard the empire. Length of service was standardized to 20 years. Every legion had an eagle standard (*aquila*).

Housesteads fort

This is the most complete Roman fort in Britain and was built c. 122 CE on Hadrian's Wall on the northern border of the empire.



the nickname “Marius's Mules.” Modern studies have estimated the weight based on rations for 16 days and a full set of equipment. At the end of a day spent on the

a noble family, gained supremacy as a result of his outstanding military career.

All aspects of life were controlled by the army. Soldiers were not allowed to marry formally. If, however, they did take up with a local woman while stationed in a far-flung part of the empire, and they were together when

march, they often had to set up a fortified military camp for the night, digging boundary ditches and setting up tents. Skilled engineers within the ranks also built bridges and roads, if necessary, in order to reach their destination. Training in physical fitness involved running, swimming,

The Roman Army

Perhaps nowhere can the formidable organization and ruthlessness of the Roman world be better seen than in its army. The professional standing army of several hundred thousand men at the height of the empire was a disciplined and well-trained fighting machine.

BEFORE

The Roman army was shaped by confronting enemies with successful armies of their own.

GREEK HOPLITE FORMATIONS

The ancient **Greek hoplites (infantry)** fought in organized formations. The hoplite “phalanx,” in which they stood closely together with their shields locked together, allowed them to form a **united front** against the enemy—something the Roman army used during the republic.



ANCIENT GREEK HOPLITE SOLDIERS

SPARTAN POWER

From birth to death, life in Sparta <<94–95 was tied to the army. Young boys were trained as soldiers, and the aim of the state was to produce a perfect and invincible hoplite army. Some of these values were echoed in the self-sacrifice demanded of Roman soldiers.

ALEXANDER'S ARMY

Alexander the Great's army of 30,000 infantry and 4,000 cavalry marched an average of over 20 miles (32 km) a day <<96–97.

The *aquilifer* (who carried the standard) was a coveted position. From this time, soldiers swore their allegiance to the emperor, which was key to ensuring their loyalty and in defending and protecting the empire's borders over the next two centuries.

TRIBUNUS A junior officer.

CENTURION A soldier in control of each century of 80 men.

PRIMUS PILUS The chief centurion.

CUSTOS ARMORUM The soldier in charge of weapons and equipment.

LEGATUS LEGIONIS The commander of the legion.

PRAEFECTUS CASTRORUM The camp prefect, responsible for training and equipment.

IMMUNES Those who were excused from regular duties, including medical staff, surveyors, and armorers.

Life in the army

Although the life of a Roman soldier was dangerous and brutal, for many it was an escape from a life of poverty. It was also a way for those without money to gain political power and influence. Young men were expected to do military service as part of their education. Those from wealthier backgrounds saw the army as a step on the ladder to public office. One striking example of the positive effect a successful military career could have is Julius Caesar, who, although born into

he retired, she was given Roman citizenship in her own right.

Although the army was feared by many, it was scrupulously disciplined and generally dealt fairly with local people it came in contact with. Supplies were paid for, rather than taken, and a good general would not allow his troops to loot and pillage at random.

Fitness and training

New recruits had to be physically fit. They were expected to march up to 20 miles (30 km) a day, carrying all their equipment, which may have weighed 60 lb (30 kg) or more—earning them

wrestling, and throwing games.

Exercises designed to build stamina might last for two days without rest. The men also practiced military drills and training, as in battle every soldier would be expected to follow commands and fight in formation. One of the most famous of these was the “tortoise” (*testudo*), in which rectangular blocs of soldiers stood together with their shields facing outward and upward toward the enemy.

The life of a Roman soldier was tough, but the discipline, effective leadership, and organization were key to its success for so long.



Army skills

Soldiers learned many skills. This roof tile, made by the 20th legion, features their charging boar emblem.

HOW WE KNOW

VINDOLANDA TABLET

These scraps of wood were found in a waterlogged trash pile near a Roman fort in northern England. They provide a detailed snapshot of life on the frontier of the empire from 97 to 103 CE. As well as personal letters from women and servants—including a birthday invitation—the tablets reveal details about the army. Work rotas, accounts, and reports give us an idea of everyday life as a Roman soldier.

